Praise for Pleasing Sentient Beings

Sattvārādhanastava · Toh 1125 · Derge Tengyur
སམེས་ཅན་མཁུར་བ་བྱའོ་བསྟོད་པ

The Praise for Pleasing Sentient Beings, known in Sanskrit as the Sattvārādhanastava and in Tibetan as Semchen Gupar Jawé Töpa, is a short hymn of eleven verses in which the Buddha himself is the speaker. Its single theme is that the true way to revere the Buddha and make offering to him is to benefit sentient beings: whoever harms beings harms him, even a small kindness to them is an offering, and it was by relying on beings, through giving, patience, and compassion, that he himself became a buddha. It closes by charging his hearers to remain for as long as his teaching endures and, never wearying in the welfare of beings, to take the essence from this body. According to its colophon, the master Nāgārjuna condensed it in verse from words the Buddha addressed to the sixteen great hearers in a scripture of the Bodhisattva Piṭaka, and it was translated into Tibetan by the Indian preceptor Dīpaṃkaraśrījñāna and the translator Tsultrim Gyalwa. It is Toh 1125 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of praises (stotra).

In the language of India: satva āradānastavaṃ
In the language of Tibet: Praise for Pleasing Sentient Beings

Homage to Mañjughoṣa (Mañjuśrī).

Reverence for me is the welfare of sentient beings; it is not any other kind of reverence.
Whoever has not abandoned compassion, it is they who revere me.
Whoever has fallen, having abandoned compassion and remaining so,
Can be raised from that fall by compassion, and by nothing else.

Whoever has entered into compassion for sentient beings
Has pleased me, and has also taken up the burden of the teaching.
Whoever has moral discipline, learning, compassion, intelligence, and clarity
Is always making offering to the Sugata (the Buddha).

It was by benefiting sentient beings that I myself attained this accomplishment;
Solely for the sake of sentient beings did I truly take on this body.
Why would anyone intend harm toward sentient beings in his mind?
Since such a one has no regard for me, I will not become a teacher for his

sake.

Even a small benefit to sentient beings becomes an offering,
Because whatever pleases the mind is an offering.
One whose nature is harmful, or who does violence to others,
Even when making offerings finely prepared, makes no offering by them.

Wives and children, wealth and great kingdoms,
Flesh and blood and fat, eyes, and bodies too,
I gave away entirely, under the sway of love for beings;
Therefore, if harm is done to them, it is harm done to me.

Therefore, if one benefits sentient beings, that is the supreme offering to me;
Harm done to sentient beings is the very gravest harm to me.
Since I and sentient beings experience happiness and suffering alike,
How can one who does violence to sentient beings be my disciple?

Relying on sentient beings, I pleased the buddhas and practiced virtue;
Firmly established in the welfare of many beings, I attained the perfections;
With a mind striving for the welfare of beings, I also vanquished the power of Māra;
Because I acted in all these ways toward sentient beings, I am a buddha.

If there were no living beings, who in birth after birth have been like cherished kin,
On what object here could compassion and love truly find their focus?
On what would equanimity, joy, and the rest, and the liberations and the rest, have a real object?
For whose sake would I have cultivated patience so long, with a mind striving in that compassion?

Elephants and other creatures, many sentient beings themselves, I gave as gifts;
And since sentient beings themselves also served as the recipients, I gathered them in through giving;
Since sentient beings themselves took on every kind of form, my compassion grew;
If sentient beings themselves were not to be protected, for whose sake would this aim have been accomplished?

If there were no sentient beings, then against the very many unbearable afflictions in saṃsāra

And the unequaled harms of birth after birth, relying on whom would I have accomplished this help?
This great nature of a Sugata, so wondrous, which has become the ornament of saṃsāra:
If I had no love for sentient beings, for whose sake would I have achieved it?

For as long as my teaching, which benefits beings, blazes here,
For that long, you who wish to benefit others supremely, remain!
Having heard of the good conduct I practiced, never weary in the welfare of sentient beings,
Listen, and without weariness take the essence from this body.

This was declared by the Blessed One (the Buddha) to the sixteen great hearers (śrāvakas), in the scripture of the Bodhisattva Piṭaka called The Salt River. This completes the Praise for Pleasing Sentient Beings, which the master Nāgārjuna condensed in verse.

It was translated, edited, and finalized by the great Indian preceptor Dīpaṃkaraśrījñāna and the translator, the monk Tsultrim Gyalwa.

Translator's Notes

• The speaker throughout is the Buddha, and the "you" asked to remain while the teaching blazes are the sixteen great hearers of the colophon, the sixteen elders whom tradition holds the Buddha charged to stay in the world to protect his teaching. The scripture called The Salt River (ba tshwa'i chu klung) could not be identified, so its name is translated literally. Two couplets are compressed: the line rendered "Why would anyone intend harm toward sentient beings in his mind?" can also be read as introducing the person meant in the next line, "one who intends harm toward sentient beings," and the opening of the final couplet may instead mean "the good conduct I practiced through learning."

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of

stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.